

Cypher is Turing-Complete: A Formal Proof via 2-Counter Machine Simulation

Pierre Halftermeyer
pierre.halftermeyer@neo4j.com
Neo4j
France

ABSTRACT

We prove that Cypher 25, the graph query language of Neo4j, is Turing-complete. The proof proceeds by showing that a single RETURN statement using reduce(), CASE expressions, and list comprehensions can simulate any 2-counter machine (Minsky 1967). We address the bounded-step objection via two complementary resolutions and verify the construction by executing the simulation on a live Neo4j Aura instance.

KEYWORDS

Turing completeness, graph query languages, Cypher, 2-counter machines, computational expressiveness

1 THE CLAIM

Theorem

Cypher 25, restricted to a single RETURN with reduce(), list comprehensions, and CASE, is **Turing-complete**.

Proof strategy. By reduction: $TM \xrightarrow{\text{Minsky}} 2CM \xrightarrow{\text{this}} \text{Cypher}$.

2 2-COUNTER MACHINES

A **2-counter machine** $M = (Q, q_0, q_h, \delta)$ has a finite state set Q , initial state q_0 , halt state q_h , and transition function $\delta : Q \rightarrow \text{Instr}$ where each instruction is:

- $\text{INC}(c, q')$ — increment $c \in \{A, B\}$, goto q'
- $\text{JZDEC}(c, q_z, q_p)$ — if $c=0$ goto q_z , else decrement and goto q_p

Fact (Minsky 1967)

For any TM T , $\exists$ a 2-counter machine simulating T .

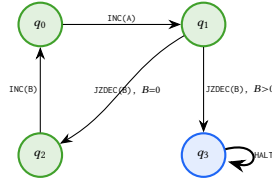


Figure 1: Example 4-state program.

3 ENCODING

Program. Encode δ as a list of maps:

```
LET program = [
  {state:0, op:'INC', counter:'A', next:1},
  {state:1, op:'JZDEC', counter:'B',
```

```
  q_zero:2, q_pos:3},
  {state:2, op:'INC', counter:'B', next:0},
  {state:3, op:'HALT', counter:'', next:3}
]
```

State. Configuration (q, c_A, c_B) as map $\{\text{state}:0, A:0, B:0\}$. Convention: $\text{state}=-1$ means halted.

4 THE SIMULATION

Each reduce() iteration executes one machine step. The head([v IN [e] ...]) idiom provides let-binding inside reduce() (where LET is unavailable).

```
CYPHER 25
LET program = [ /* ... */ ]
LET max_steps = 1000000

LET result = reduce(
  machine = {state:0, A:0, B:0},
  step IN range(1, max_steps) |
  CASE WHEN machine.state = -1
  THEN machine
  ELSE
    head([instr IN [program[machine.state]] |
      CASE instr.op
      WHEN 'INC' THEN
        CASE instr.counter
          WHEN 'A' THEN {state: instr.next,
            A: machine.A + 1, B: machine.B}
          WHEN 'B' THEN {state: instr.next,
            A: machine.A, B: machine.B + 1}
        END
      WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN
        CASE instr.counter
          WHEN 'A' THEN
            CASE WHEN machine.A = 0
            THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
              A: 0, B: machine.B}
            ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
              A: machine.A-1, B: machine.B}
          END
          WHEN 'B' THEN
            CASE WHEN machine.B = 0
            THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
              A: machine.A, B: 0}
            ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
              A: machine.A, B: machine.B-1}
          END
        END
      WHEN 'HALT' THEN
        {state: -1, A: machine.A, B: machine.B}
    END
  )
```

```

    })
  END
}
RETURN result

```

5 CORRECTNESS

Claim

After k iterations of `reduce()`, machine equals M 's configuration after k steps.

Base. $k=0$: machine = $\{0, 0, 0\} = M_0$. ✓

Step. Assume machine = (q_k, a_k, b_k) matches M . At $k+1$, `reduce()` looks up $\delta(q_k)$ and executes:

`INC(A, q')` → (q', a_k+1, b_k) ✓

`JZDEC(A, ..),  $a_k=0$` → $(q_z, 0, b_k)$ ✓

`JZDEC(A, ..),  $a_k>0$` → (q_p, a_k-1, b_k) ✓

`HALT` → $(-1, ..)$, identity after ✓

Symmetric for B . □

6 THE BOUNDED-STEP OBJECTION

The `reduce()` uses `range(1, max_steps)` — a finite bound.

6.1 Resolution via IN TRANSACTIONS

While the pure functional version stays within a single expression, the practical unbounded version uses graph storage for state persistence.

```

CYPHER 25
CREATE (:Machine {state:0, A:0, B:0});

UNWIND range(1, 9223372036854775807) AS step
CALL (step) {
  MATCH (m:Machine)
  WITH m,
  CASE WHEN m.state = -1 THEN 1/0
        ELSE $program[m.state]
  END AS instr
  SET m.state = CASE instr.op
  WHEN 'INC' THEN instr.next
  WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN CASE instr.counter
    WHEN 'A' THEN CASE WHEN m.A = 0
      THEN instr.q_zero ELSE instr.q_pos END
    WHEN 'B' THEN CASE WHEN m.B = 0
      THEN instr.q_zero ELSE instr.q_pos END
    END
  WHEN 'HALT' THEN -1 END,
  m.A = CASE
  WHEN instr.op='INC' AND instr.counter='A'
    THEN m.A+1
  WHEN instr.op='JZDEC' AND instr.counter='A'
    AND m.A > 0 THEN m.A-1
  ELSE m.A END,
  m.B = CASE
  WHEN instr.op='INC' AND instr.counter='B'
    THEN m.B+1
  WHEN instr.op='JZDEC' AND instr.counter='B'
    AND m.B > 0 THEN m.B-1

```

```

    ELSE m.B END
  } IN TRANSACTIONS OF 1 ROW
  ON ERROR BREAK

```

Termination. At halt, state becomes -1 . Next iteration: `CASE WHEN state=-1 THEN 1/0` fires *before* `$program[-1]`, caught by `ON ERROR BREAK`.

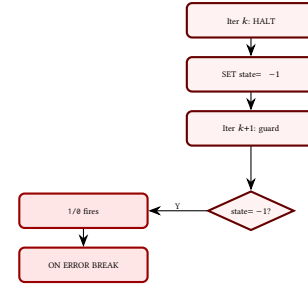


Figure 2: Termination via `1/0` + `ON ERROR BREAK`.

Note. $2^{63} \approx 9.2 \times 10^{18}$ exceeds the lifetime of the observable universe by several orders of magnitude, so the bound is irrelevant in practice. True theoretical unboundedness would need an external restart loop.

6.2 Sufficiency Argument

For TM T halting in $f(|w|)$ steps: set `max_steps = f(|w|)`. Cypher correctly decides every decidable language — **universal for total functions**.

7 REQUIRED PRIMITIVES

Primitive	Role
<code>reduce()</code>	Iteration (fold)
<code>CASE WHEN</code>	Branching
<code>+1, -1, = 0</code>	Counter ops
<code>Map {s,A,B}</code>	State repr.
<code>prog[i]</code>	$O(1)$ lookup
<code>head([..])</code>	Let-binding

No graph operations. No APOC. No GDS.

8 COROLLARIES

Corollary 1: Undecidability of termination

Since CYPHER 25 can simulate any 2-counter machine, it is *undecidable* whether a given `reduce()` expression will terminate. (By Rice's theorem applied to the reduction from 2CM.)

Corollary 2: Practical implications

Cypher can compute any computable function: game-tree search via nested `reduce()` with alpha-beta pruning, Gaussian elimination via list-of-lists, genetic algorithms via iterated `reduce()` over populations, and any algorithm expressible as a fold.

Corollary 3: Beyond computability

While `reduce()` makes Cypher Turing-complete for *computation*, graph pattern matching with QPP and `allReduce` provides *declarative constrained traversal* with per-step pruning — something most Turing-complete languages lack. This is not about computability (all TC languages are equivalent) but about **expressiveness**: some problems are more naturally expressed as graph patterns than as imperative loops.

9 VERIFIED EXECUTION

Both approaches tested on Neo4j Aura (Neo4j 5.x, Cypher 25). Test program: 4 instructions, expected $\{-1, 2, 0\}$.

Step	Instr	St	A	B
0	INC(A)	q_0	$0 \rightarrow 1$	0
1	JZDEC(B), $B=0$	q_1	1	0
2	INC(B)	q_2	1	$0 \rightarrow 1$
3	INC(A)	q_0	$1 \rightarrow 2$	1
4	JZDEC(B), $B>0$	q_1	2	$1 \rightarrow 0$
5	HALT	q_3	2	0

{A:2, B:0, state:-1} ✓

m.state=-1, m.A=2, m.B=0 ✓

10 COMPLETE RUNNABLE QUERIES

The following two queries are copy-paste ready for any Neo4j instance with Cypher 25 support. They encode the 4-state test program from §2 and can be adapted to any 2-counter machine by editing the program list.

10.1 Approach 1: Pure `reduce()`

A single `RETURN` statement — no graph writes, no side effects. The `head([v IN [expr] | ...])` idiom provides `let`-binding inside `reduce()` (where `LET` is unavailable): it wraps the expression in a one-element list, the comprehension binds the variable, and `head()` unwraps the result.

```
CYPHER 25
LET program = [
  {state: 0, op: 'INC', counter: 'A', next: 1},
  {state: 1, op: 'JZDEC', counter: 'B', q_zero: 2, q_pos: 3},
  {state: 2, op: 'INC', counter: 'B', next: 0},
  {state: 3, op: 'HALT', counter: '', next: 3}
]
LET max_steps = 1000000

LET result = reduce(
  machine = {state: 0, A: 0, B: 0},
```

```
step IN range(1, max_steps) |
CASE WHEN machine.state = -1
THEN machine
ELSE
  head([instr IN [program[machine.state]] |
    CASE instr.op
      WHEN 'INC' THEN
        CASE instr.counter
          WHEN 'A' THEN
            {state: instr.next,
             A: machine.A + 1, B: machine.B}
          WHEN 'B' THEN
            {state: instr.next,
             A: machine.A, B: machine.B + 1}
        END
      WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN
        CASE instr.counter
          WHEN 'A' THEN
            CASE WHEN machine.A = 0
            THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
                  A: 0, B: machine.B}
            ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
                  A: machine.A - 1,
                  B: machine.B}
          WHEN 'B' THEN
            CASE WHEN machine.B = 0
            THEN {state: instr.q_zero,
                  A: machine.A, B: 0}
            ELSE {state: instr.q_pos,
                  A: machine.A,
                  B: machine.B - 1}
          END
        END
      WHEN 'HALT' THEN
        {state: -1,
         A: machine.A, B: machine.B}
    END
  ])
END
RETURN result
```

10.2 Approach 2: IN TRANSACTIONS

Uses graph storage for state persistence. The $1/0$ guard fires *before* any list indexing when halted, caught by `ON ERROR BREAK`.

```
CYPHER 25
CREATE (:Machine {state: 0, A: 0, B: 0});
```

```
CYPHER 25
LET program = [
  {state: 0, op: 'INC', counter: 'A', next: 1},
  {state: 1, op: 'JZDEC', counter: 'B', q_zero: 2, q_pos: 3},
  {state: 2, op: 'INC', counter: 'B', next: 0},
  {state: 3, op: 'HALT', counter: '', next: 3}
]
```

```

UNWIND range(1, 9223372036854775807) AS step
CALL (step) {
  MATCH (m:Machine)
  WITH m,
    CASE WHEN m.state = -1 THEN 1/0
    ELSE program[m.state]
  END AS instr
  SET m.state = CASE instr.op
  WHEN 'INC' THEN instr.next
  WHEN 'JZDEC' THEN
    CASE instr.counter
    WHEN 'A' THEN
      CASE WHEN m.A = 0
      THEN instr.q_zero
      ELSE instr.q_pos END
    WHEN 'B' THEN
      CASE WHEN m.B = 0
      THEN instr.q_zero
      ELSE instr.q_pos END
    END
  WHEN 'HALT' THEN -1
  END,
  m.A = CASE
  WHEN instr.op = 'INC'
  AND instr.counter = 'A'
  THEN m.A + 1
  WHEN instr.op = 'JZDEC'
  AND instr.counter = 'A'
  AND m.A > 0 THEN m.A - 1
  ELSE m.A END,
  m.B = CASE
  WHEN instr.op = 'INC'
  AND instr.counter = 'B'
  THEN m.B + 1
  WHEN instr.op = 'JZDEC'
  AND instr.counter = 'B'
  AND m.B > 0 THEN m.B - 1
  ELSE m.B END
} IN TRANSACTIONS OF 1 ROW
ON ERROR BREAK

```

```

// Read result:
MATCH (m:Machine) RETURN m;

```

10.3 Approach 3: Graph-Native QPP Traversal

The most idiomatic approach: model the machine *as a graph* and let pattern matching *be* the computation. Each state is a node; each transition is a relationship. JZDEC splits into two edges (JZDEC_ZERO, JZDEC_POS); the predicate in `allReduce` prunes the invalid branch at traversal time.

```

CYPHER 25
// Build the machine as a graph
CREATE (q0:State:Init {id: 0})
CREATE (q1:State {id: 1})
CREATE (q2:State {id: 2})
CREATE (q3:State:Halt {id: 3})
CREATE (q0)-[:INC {c:'A'}]->(q1)
CREATE (q1)-[:JZDEC_ZERO {c:'B'}]->(q2)
CREATE (q1)-[:JZDEC_POS {c:'B'}]->(q3)
CREATE (q2)-[:INC {c:'B'}]->(q0)

```

```

CYPHER 25
// Traverse: allReduce prunes, NEXT extracts
MATCH REPEATABLE ELEMENTS
p = (init:Init)
-[rels:INC|JZDEC_ZERO|JZDEC_POS]->
{1, 9223372036854775807}
(h:Halt)
WHERE allReduce(
  m = {A: 0, B: 0}, r IN rels |
  CASE
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A+1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B+1}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A-1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B-1}
    ELSE m
  END,
  CASE
    WHEN r:JZDEC_ZERO AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN m.A = 0
    WHEN r:JZDEC_ZERO AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN m.B = 0
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN m.A >= 0
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN m.B >= 0
    ELSE true
  END
)
RETURN rels, length(p) AS steps
NEXT
// Re-derive counters from the valid path
LET final = reduce(m = {A:0, B:0},
  r IN rels |
  CASE
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A+1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:INC AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B+1}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'A'
    THEN {A: m.A-1, B: m.B}
    WHEN r:JZDEC_POS AND r.c = 'B'
    THEN {A: m.A, B: m.B-1}
    ELSE m
  END
)
RETURN steps, final.A AS ctrA, final.B AS ctrB

```

Key properties:

- The machine *is* the graph; computation *is* path finding
- REPEATABLE ELEMENTS allows revisiting states (loops)
- `allReduce` prunes eagerly: once a JZDEC branch fails the predicate, that path is abandoned immediately
- No HALT self-loop needed — reaching a `:Halt` node terminates the pattern
- `reduce()` in the NEXT stage re-derives final counter values from the surviving path (same pattern as [5])

REFERENCES

- [1] Minsky, M.L. 1967. *Computation: Finite and Infinite Machines*. Prentice-Hall.

Cypher is Turing-Complete:
A Formal Proof via 2-Counter Machine Simulation

- [2] openCypher. 2024. Cypher Query Language Reference. <https://opencypher.org>
- [3] ISO/IEC 39075:2024. *Information technology — Database languages — GQL*. International Organization for Standardization.
- [4] Neo4j. 2025. *Cypher Manual*. <https://neo4j.com/docs/cypher-manual/current/>
- [5] Halftermeyer, P. 2025. Declarative Route Planning for EVs With Neo4j — Graph Traversal Grows Up. <https://neo4j.com/blog/developer/declarative-route-planning-with-cypher-25/>
- [6] Halftermeyer, P. 2015–2025. Advent of Code in Pure Cypher — 150+ puzzles solved purely in Cypher, empirical evidence of expressiveness. <https://github.com/halftermeyer/adventofcode>